

Opportunity Backlog

A structured template for tracking candidate automation opportunities identified through **Metrics Based Process Mapping**. Use this backlog to move from workshop discussion to follow-up action — capturing process, pain point, evidence, likely response, category, next best action, owner and status.

DISCOVERY TOOL

AUTOMATION PLANNING

PROCESS IMPROVEMENT

Map the work. Measure the pain. Automate with purpose.

Purpose

This backlog helps teams move from workshop outputs to evidence-based decisions. It is an **early-stage discovery backlog** — not a detailed delivery backlog.



Capture Consistently

Record candidate automation opportunities in a consistent format so nothing is lost after a workshop.



Track Evidence

Log known evidence and flag missing metrics so follow-up actions are clear and owned.



Compare Opportunities

Evaluate opportunities using value, feasibility and readiness to prioritise what moves forward.



Build a Pipeline

Identify which opportunities move into automation discovery, process improvement or further investigation.

When to Use This Backlog

After a Metrics Based Process Mapping Workshop

Capture all candidate opportunities surfaced during the session before they are forgotten.

After a Scenario Clinic

Record ideas and pain points raised when walking through specific process scenarios.

When Comparing Multiple Automation Ideas

Use the backlog to compare opportunities side by side using consistent criteria.

When Tracking Missing Metrics or Evidence

Flag what is unknown and assign owners to gather the data needed before a decision can be made.

Before Moving into Discovery or Delivery

Use the backlog as a lightweight gate before committing to deeper discovery or design work.

How to Use This Backlog

Follow these steps to populate and maintain the backlog effectively. Focus on the **next best action**, not the final solution.

O1

Add Each Candidate Process or Opportunity as a Row

Give each opportunity a unique ID (e.g. OPP-001) and a clear process name.

O3

Record Known and Missing Evidence

Log what you know and flag what still needs to be gathered, with an owner assigned.

O5

Categorise the Opportunity

Assign one of the four standard categories to guide the next best action.

O2

Capture the Pain Point in Plain Language

Describe the problem simply — effort, delay, rework, risk or poor visibility.

O4

Identify the Likely Response

Select from: automation, improvement, both, investigation or defer.

O6

Assign an Owner and Review Regularly

Every next best action needs an owner. Review the backlog on a regular cadence and update status.

Opportunity Categories

Use these four categories consistently across all backlog entries. The category drives the next best action.

Automate Now

High value, feasible and ready.

Move into automation discovery or design. Strong evidence exists and the process is stable.

Improve First

Worth solving, but process needs tidying.

Clarify, simplify, standardise or assign ownership before attempting automation.

Investigate Further

Potential value, but more evidence is needed.

Gather data or assess technical feasibility before making a category decision.

Do Not Automate Yet

Low value, unstable or unclear.

Defer or address underlying process issues first. Not ready does not mean not worth improving.

 Remember: **Not ready for automation does not mean not worth improving.** Every category has a valid next action.

Status Values

Use these status values to track where each opportunity sits in the pipeline. Teams can adapt these to match their own delivery or governance process.

New	Captured but not yet reviewed
Needs Evidence	Missing metrics or evidence need to be gathered
Needs Process Validation	Current process needs to be confirmed with people who do the work
Needs Technical Assessment	Feasibility depends on systems, data or integration options
Improve First	Process improvement is required before automation can be considered
Ready for Discovery	Opportunity is ready for deeper automation discovery
In Discovery	Detailed discovery or analysis is underway
Deferred	Not currently being progressed
Closed	No further action required or opportunity has been completed

Backlog Summary

Complete this section to record the ownership and review cadence for the backlog. Update before each review session.

Backlog Metadata

Keep this section current so the team always knows who owns the backlog and when it was last reviewed.

- Assign a named backlog owner
- Record the date created and last reviewed
- Link to the related workshop or session
- Add any relevant notes for context

Backlog Owner	[OWNER / TEAM]
Date Created	[DATE]
Last Reviewed	[DATE]
Review Cadence	Weekly / Fortnightly / Monthly / Ad hoc
Related Workshop / Session	[SESSION NAME OR DATE]
Notes	[NOTES]

Opportunity Backlog Table

Add each candidate opportunity as a row. Keep entries concise and focus on evidence, not opinions. Update status and next best action regularly.

ID	Process / Opportunity	Pain Point	Known Evidence	Missing Evidence	Likely Response	Category	Next Best Action	Owner	Status
OPP-001	[PROCESS NAME]	[PAIN POINT]	[KNOWN EVIDENCE]	[MISSING EVIDENCE]	Automation / Improvement / Both / Investigate / Defer	Automate now / Improve first / Investigate further / Do not automate yet	[NEXT ACTION]	[OWNER]	New
OPP-002	[PROCESS NAME]	[PAIN POINT]	[KNOWN EVIDENCE]	[MISSING EVIDENCE]	Automation / Improvement / Both / Investigate / Defer	Automate now / Improve first / Investigate further / Do not automate yet	[NEXT ACTION]	[OWNER]	New
OPP-003	[PROCESS NAME]	[PAIN POINT]	[KNOWN EVIDENCE]	[MISSING EVIDENCE]	Automation / Improvement / Both / Investigate / Defer	Automate now / Improve first / Investigate further / Do not automate yet	[NEXT ACTION]	[OWNER]	New

 Add a new row for each opportunity. Copy the format above. Assign an ID sequentially (OPP-004, OPP-005, etc.).

Detailed Opportunity Record

Use this section when an opportunity needs more detail than the backlog table allows. Copy this template for each opportunity that requires deeper documentation.

Opportunity Identification

Opportunity ID	[OPP-###]
Opportunity Name	[PROCESS / OPPORTUNITY NAME]
Short Description	[Briefly describe the process or opportunity.]
Why This Matters	[Explain why the process matters and who is affected.]
Pain Point Summary	[Summarise the main pain point: effort, delay, rework, risk, user impact or poor visibility.]

Value, Feasibility and Readiness

Lens	Assessment	Notes
Value	High / Medium / Low / Unknown	[NOTES]
Feasibility	High / Medium / Low / Unknown	[NOTES]
Readiness	High / Medium / Low / Unknown	[NOTES]

Current Evidence

Evidence / Metric	Value or Estimate	Source	Confidence
Volume	[VALUE]	[SOURCE]	High / Med / Low
Cycle time	[VALUE]	[SOURCE]	High / Med / Low
Touch time	[VALUE]	[SOURCE]	High / Med / Low
Wait time	[VALUE]	[SOURCE]	High / Med / Low
Rework / errors	[VALUE]	[SOURCE]	High / Med / Low
Exceptions	[VALUE]	[SOURCE]	High / Med / Low
Risk impact	[VALUE]	[SOURCE]	High / Med / Low
User impact	[VALUE]	[SOURCE]	High / Med / Low

Missing Evidence

Missing Evidence	Why It Matters	Source / Who Can Help	Owner
[MISSING EVIDENCE]	[WHY IT MATTERS]	[SOURCE / PERSON]	[OWNER]
[MISSING EVIDENCE]	[WHY IT MATTERS]	[SOURCE / PERSON]	[OWNER]

Likely Response

Automation	Process Improvement	Automation + Improvement
Further Investigation	Defer for Now	

Select the most appropriate response above and record the rationale below.

Opportunity Category	Automate now / Improve first / Investigate further / Do not automate yet
Rationale	[Explain why this category was selected.]
Next Best Action	[Capture the next best action.]

Follow-up Actions

Action	Owner	Due Date	Status	Notes
[ACTION]	[OWNER]	[DATE]	[STATUS]	[NOTES]
[ACTION]	[OWNER]	[DATE]	[STATUS]	[NOTES]

Decision Log

Date	Decision / Update	Owner / Decision-Maker	Notes
[DATE]	[DECISION OR UPDATE]	[OWNER]	[NOTES]
[DATE]	[DECISION OR UPDATE]	[OWNER]	[NOTES]

Prioritisation View

Use this optional view to compare opportunities side by side. The pattern of value, feasibility and readiness scores guides the recommended next action.

ID	Opportunity	Value	Feasibility	Readiness	Category	Priority	Notes
OPP-001	[OPPORTUNITY]	High / Med / Low	High / Med / Low	High / Med / Low	[CATEGORY]	High / Med / Low	[NOTES]
OPP-002	[OPPORTUNITY]	High / Med / Low	High / Med / Low	High / Med / Low	[CATEGORY]	High / Med / Low	[NOTES]
OPP-003	[OPPORTUNITY]	High / Med / Low	High / Med / Low	High / Med / Low	[CATEGORY]	High / Med / Low	[NOTES]

Suggested Interpretation

High Value + High Feasibility + High Readiness

Strong candidate — consider moving into discovery or design immediately.

High Value + Medium / Low Readiness

Improve first — clarify process, ownership or rules before automating.

High Value + Unclear Feasibility

Investigate further — a technical or data assessment is needed before proceeding.

Low Value + High Feasibility

Possible quick tidy-up, but may not be a priority. Consider deferring.

Low Value + Low Readiness

Defer or address underlying process issues first. Do not invest further at this stage.

Example Backlog Entries

These are illustrative examples only — use them as a guide for how to populate the backlog table with real opportunities from your workshop.

ID	Process / Opportunity	Pain Point	Known Evidence	Missing Evidence	Likely Response	Category	Next Best Action	Owner	Status
OPP-001	New starter access request	Missing information, approval delay and manual provisioning	30% requests need clarification; 2–5 day cycle time; 25–35 mins touch time	Actual volume; approval delay; standard access patterns	Improvement + automation	Improve first / Investigate further	Validate standard path and gather actual metrics	[OWNER]	Need evidence
OPP-002	Weekly operational status report	Manual coordination, inconsistent inputs and report formatting	3–5 hrs weekly effort; 10–15 handoffs; 2–3 corrections per week	Actual effort over 4 cycles; source of truth; export options	Improvement + selected automation	Improve first / Automate selected steps	Standardise inputs and test reminders	[OWNER]	Improve first
OPP-003	Standard password reset request	High volume and repetitive support activity	200 requests per month; 10 mins touch time each	Current self-service usage; failure reasons	Automation	Automate now	Confirm identity and security requirements	[OWNER]	Ready for discussion

✔ OPP-003 is a strong candidate: high volume, repetitive, clear evidence and a stable process. This is the pattern to look for when categorising as **Automate now**.

Review Cadence

Define how the backlog will be reviewed and what is expected from each session. A backlog is only useful if it helps the team make decisions.

Review Setup

Review Owner	[OWNER]
Review Cadence	Weekly / Fortnightly / Monthly / Ad hoc
Review Forum	[MEETING / CHANNEL / GROUP]
Inputs Required	[WHAT NEEDS TO BE UPDATED BEFORE REVIEW?]
Outputs Expected	[WHAT DECISIONS OR ACTIONS SHOULD COME FROM REVIEW?]

Suggested Review Questions

- Has any missing evidence been gathered?
- Has the process been validated with people who do the work?
- Has the category changed?
- Is the next best action still current?
- Does the opportunity need technical assessment?
- Should this move into deeper discovery?
- Should this be deferred or closed?

Backlog Hygiene

To keep the backlog useful and decision-ready, follow these hygiene principles. A cluttered or stale backlog creates noise, not clarity.

→ Keep Entries Concise

Avoid lengthy descriptions. Capture the essentials: pain point, evidence and next action.

→ Focus on Evidence, Not Opinions

Ground every entry in data or observed behaviour. Flag assumptions clearly.

→ Update Missing Metrics as They Are Gathered

When evidence arrives, update the entry and reassess the category and status.

→ Close or Defer Low-Value Items

Do not let the backlog grow indefinitely. Remove items that are no longer relevant.

→ Review Categories Regularly

Categories can change as evidence improves or process conditions shift.

→ Assign Owners for Every Follow-up Action

An unowned action is an action that will not happen. Every next step needs a name against it.

⚠️ Avoid turning every idea into a delivery item. The backlog is a decision-making tool, not a commitment register.

Final Reminder

The opportunity backlog is not just a list of automation ideas. It is a record of evidence-led opportunities, assumptions, missing data and next actions.

Use it to help answer five essential questions:

1. What is worth solving?

Focus effort on pain points with real impact on people, time or quality.

2. What is ready to automate?

Only automate what is stable, understood and evidenced.

3. What needs to improve first?

Automating a broken process makes a broken process faster. Fix it first.

4. What needs more evidence?

Do not guess. Assign an owner to gather the missing data.

5. What should we do next?

Every backlog review should end with a clear, owned next best action.

Map the work. Measure the pain. Automate with purpose.